

THE RELOCATION GUIDE

5 questions to ask before you relocate *to Greater Boston.*

A short field guide for buyers moving to Greater Boston from outside the area. The questions inside are the ones that separate a relocation that lands well from one that becomes an expensive lesson.

BEFORE YOU START

Greater Boston is *not one market*.

Most relocations get planned around a job, a school, or a partner's career. The work part is decided. The reason to move is identified. The decision becomes "where do we live near it." From the outside, Greater Boston looks like a single market. From inside, it is dozens of very different ones, with prices, commutes, schools, parking, taxes, and personalities that change block by block. The relocation that gets planned on a national real estate site almost never matches the relocation that gets lived once you arrive.

The relocators I have watched land well do not pick a town from a list and start touring. They start with what their actual life needs to look like once they get here. The commute they can actually live with. The kind of neighborhood that fits their weekends. The price band that lets the rest of their life keep working. Then they let the right submarket reveal itself, instead of forcing a search to fit a town someone told them was "the one." These are the five questions I walk every relocating client through before we start touring.

How to use this guide

Read all five. Try the exercise at the end of each one. Bring the answers, or the questions you cannot answer, to whoever you trust to help you decide. Or bring them to me on a 30 minute strategy session, which we can do remotely. There is no commitment to buy.

01

QUESTION ONE · THE LIFE SHAPE

What does your actual day-to-day need to look like *once you get here*?

WHY IT MATTERS

Most relocations get reduced to a checklist. Square footage. Bedrooms. Schools. Maybe walkability. The checklist gets built before the day-to-day gets imagined. The result is a home that meets all the boxes on paper and still feels wrong six months in, because the actual shape of the life being lived in it was never the conversation.

Picture a regular Wednesday in your new life. Where are you having coffee. Where are you working from. How are you getting to work. Where are the kids if you have them. Where is the gym, the grocery store, the bar where you would meet a new friend. The right town and the right neighborhood are the ones that make that Wednesday easier, not harder. The house lives inside the life. The life does not live inside the house.

TRY THIS

Write one paragraph describing a regular Wednesday in your life six months after the move. The places that paragraph keeps returning to are the ones the search should center around.

02

QUESTION TWO · THE MAP

Which Greater Boston submarkets actually fit your life, *and which ones just look good from outside?*

WHY IT MATTERS

Greater Boston is a dense patchwork of towns and neighborhoods that look similar on a national real estate site and behave very differently in real life. Cambridge and Somerville sit next to each other and feel different. The same street can cross a town line and change the tax rate, the school district, the parking rules, and the price per square foot. National "best places to live" lists tend to pick the towns with the biggest budgets, which is rarely the same as the towns that fit a specific buyer.

Start with three or four submarkets that actually fit your life, not your assumptions. A short commute by car versus a short commute on the T are different conversations. A town with great schools and a quiet downtown is different from a city neighborhood with great restaurants and a smaller home. A walkable square is different from a quiet street with a long driveway. The right map for you is built around your Wednesday, not someone else's ranking.

TRY THIS

List three things about a neighborhood that you genuinely will not compromise on. Then list three you secretly will. The honest list is the one that should drive the search.

03

QUESTION THREE • THE BUFFER

Are you better off buying right away, *or renting for a year first?*

WHY IT MATTERS

Most relocators feel pressure to buy quickly. The mortgage is the goal. The rent feels wasted. The plan has a closing date. That is a reasonable instinct in a familiar market. In a market you have never lived in, in a city you have never wintered in, in a neighborhood you have walked exactly twice, that same instinct can buy the wrong house in the wrong town for the wrong reason.

A short rental in an area you are 80% sure about often pays for itself in avoided mistakes. You get to see how the commute actually feels in February. You learn which neighborhood you keep finding yourself in on weekends. You discover the streets that show well in photos and feel different on foot. The cost of a six to twelve month lease is small compared to the cost of selling a house you bought too fast. Sometimes buying immediately is exactly right. Sometimes the buffer is the smarter buy.

TRY THIS

Ask honestly. Of the towns you are considering, how many have you spent more than one full day in. If the answer is none, a buffer rental is worth pricing out before you commit to buying.

04

QUESTION FOUR • THE FULL NUMBER

What does the total cost of owning here actually look like, *including everything you may not be used to?*

WHY IT MATTERS

The price tag is just the entry point. Greater Boston comes with a set of costs that buyers from other parts of the country often do not fully expect. Property taxes that vary meaningfully by town. Heating costs across a long winter, often with oil or older systems. Water and sewer bills that can surprise. Condo fees that range from reasonable to substantial depending on the building. Parking costs in city neighborhoods. Lead paint compliance in older homes. The sticker price gets one number. The all-in monthly is a different number.

Underwrite the full cost before you anchor to a price point. Mortgage, taxes, insurance, condo fees if any, utilities for an older or larger building, parking, transit, and a real maintenance reserve. Compare that all-in number to what you are paying today, not what you assume you will pay here. Some relocators discover the move is more affordable than they thought. Some discover the opposite. Either way, the decision should be made with the right number in front of you, not the wrong one.

TRY THIS

Pull together the full new monthly at three price points before you tour. Live on the middle number for one month before you write an offer. The number that still feels comfortable is your number.

How are you going to shop, offer, and buy from out of state *without overpaying or moving too fast?*

WHY IT MATTERS

Out-of-state buyers usually have less time and more pressure. Two or three trips. A relocation deadline. A spouse still working in the old city. A school year clock. That mix creates a strong temptation to write an offer on the first house that fits the checklist, often above asking, often with contingencies waived, often before the buyer has actually walked the neighborhood at three different times of day. That is how relocators quietly overpay.

Build the strategy before the trip, not during it. Decide which submarkets are in scope and which are not. Decide the price ceiling and the contingencies you will not waive. Schedule the trip around touring multiple properties in the same area to build calibration, not just to fall for one. Have someone local you trust walk the building, the block, and the nighttime feel for you. Boston rewards calibrated buyers and quietly punishes the ones who only see two houses before they write the offer.

TRY THIS

Before your house-hunting trip, write down three things. The submarkets in scope. The price ceiling. The contingencies that are non-negotiable. If the trip ends with you writing an offer that violates any of those three, the answer is to wait, not to bend.

READY WHEN YOU ARE

Want to map a move *that actually fits Greater Boston?*

These are not the only questions worth running before a relocation. They are the ones I have watched separate the moves that feel right a year later from the ones that quietly do not. If you want to walk through them on your specific situation with me, that is what a strategy session is for. We can do it remotely. No commitment to buy.

Book my strategy session

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Krista Recker Properties

Strategy first. Decisions backed by data.